of new tracks in FY 2023-24 alone, marking a 42% increase in daily train operations — from 356 trains per day in FY 2024-25 to 388 trains per day in FY 2025-26 (up to July).

These achievements didn't just boost freight volumes. They also enabled better punctuality for passenger services over Indian Railways by shifting substantial freight traffic off congested mainlines. Notably, the introduction of the "Truck on Train" service exemplifies our commitment to multimodal logistics; it's delivered faster, safer, and more sustainable road-rail cargo transfers, reducing transit times from 24–36 hours to just 10, and saving over 1 lakh liters of diesel in FY 2023-24 alone as compared to road transport.

**Q: DFCCIL emphasizes technology and modernization. What are some recent innovations that have redefined rail freight in India?**

**A.** DFCCIL is committed to technological excellence. Our corridors use advanced 2x25kV electric traction, enabling higher load trains at higher speeds. Our Operations Control Centres in Prayagraj and Ahmedabad harness state-of-the-art automation and real-time data from Indian Railways' IT backbone.

A major step is the Machine Vision-Based Inspection System (MVIS), a breakthrough AI and machine learning-enabled tool, developed in partnership with the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bangalore and DFCCIL. MVIS automates high-resolution, wayside inspection of rolling stock, instantly flagging any mechanical anomalies for immediate intervention. This, along with the strategic use of Hot Axle Box Detectors and end-to-end cargo/geolocation tracking, has not only improved safety but minimized manual interventions and potential disruptions.

**Q: What strategic and operational strengths set DFCCIL apart from conventional freight operations?**

**A.** Beyond sheer scale, DFCCIL's design reflects global best practices: our tracks support 25-ton axle load trains (with bridges and loops designed for even higher axle loads), enabling double-stack container movement — especially vital on WDFC — and facilitate the running of 1.5km-long freight trains. With a theoretical capacity of 480 trains a day, the network is configured for both present needs and future growth which has been effectively showcased with DFCCIL successful running of Rudrastra, the longest freight train in Asia, stretching 4.5 kms. This landmark achievement involved coupling of six standard freight rakes in a single unit consisting 7 locomotives and 354 wagons.

We have also implemented business-friendly policies: the Gati Shakti Cargo Terminals (GCTs) and partnerships with multimodal operators have dramatically improved cargo handling, reduced turnaround, and fostered private investment.

Our innovations have resulted in tangible benefits: increased freight competitiveness, reduced logistics costs, improved train punctuality, and environmental gains — rail emits only 28g $CO_2$ per NTKM, against 64g for roads.

**Q: How is DFCCIL contributing to India's national sustainability and economic growth agenda?**

**A.** Our work directly aligns with "Viksit Bharat @2047" and the National Logistics Policy. Transitioning freight from road to rail not only reduces costs and improves reliability, but also substantially lowers carbon emissions. Over 30 years, DFCCIL corridors are projected to save 457 million tons of $CO_2$.

We are also expanding "last-mile" connectivity via Multimodal Logistics Parks and linking less-developed regions with the national supply chain, thereby promoting inclusive growth. As part of our ecological commitment, over six lakh trees have been planted along the EDFC and WDFC corridors.

**Q: What are the major challenges DFCCIL continues to face, and how are they addressed going forward?**

**A.** Land acquisition and financing remain complex, given the capital-intensive, cross-regional nature of our projects. We address these through continuous engagement with stakeholders, transparent compensation mechanisms, and leveraging Government support for policy and funding.

Operationally, our reliance on Indian Railways for traffic and rolling stock prompts us to work ever more closely to optimize synergies. Technological integration, such as MVIS and the Dedicated Freight Information System (DFIS), helps reduce manpower demands and enhances safety with minimal manual oversight.

We're focused on diversifying our freight base to adapt to prepare for future scenario when bulk commodities such as coal and cement will become less dominant, all while scaling up private partnerships wherever possible.

**Q: How is DFCCIL leveraging the Heavy Haul Institute to train and upskill its workforce for efficient freight operations?**

**A.** DFCCIL operates India's only dedicated freight corridors, which require precision in train operation, infrastructure maintenance, and advanced technology management. Given the scale — over 2,800 km of corridor and handling more than 12% of Indian Railways' freight — skilled manpower is critical. Specialized training ensures employees are well-versed in heavy haul logistics, safety protocols, and more.

The Heavy Haul Institute (HHI) is a premier training and research body under DFCCIL aimed at skilling and reskilling employees for operating and maintaining high-capacity freight systems. Located in Noida, HHI was conceptualized to cater to the specific needs of heavy freight operations including axle load dynamics, long-haul train operation, advanced signaling, and green logistics.

As of July 2025, HHI has trained over 3,200 personnel, including engineers, station controllers, loco pilots, and operations planners. Approximately, 1,200 employees have undergone hands-on simulation-based training in Train Management System (TMS). 900 employees received sustainability and green logistics modules.

**Q: Where do you see DFCCIL on the international stage?**

**A.** DFCCIL has been designed to not just match, but in many respects exceed, global standards. We have implemented several world-first innovations in track laying, tunnel boring, signalling, and electrification. The entire infrastructure has been compatible for 32.5-ton axle load trains, placing DFCCIL firmly in the category of Heavy Haul Railways — a benchmark achieved by only a select group of rail systems worldwide. This positions us to collaborate, compete, and be recognized alongside the most advanced freight rail networks internationally. Recently, we hosted the Global Heavy Haul Seminar, which drew delegates from over 7 countries and received global acclaim — further underscoring DFCCIL's standing on the international stage.

**Q: Finally, what is your vision for DFCCIL as it transitions from project completion to an operational powerhouse?**

**A.** With just 4% of the IR network, DFCCIL handles 13% of the total freight GTKM — carrying more freight than any individual zone of Indian Railways.

The future is about transformation. DFCCIL's seamless, efficient corridors are poised to anchor India's next wave of industrial and economic growth. We're moving from construction to operations — supporting industrial corridors, new private freight terminals, multimodal parks, and e-commerce distribution. Our vision is clear: enable Indian Railways to regain — and expand — its freight market share, power "Make in India" and "One District, One Product" initiatives, and position India as a global supply chain leader.

Crucially, we will continue to embrace innovation, sustainability, and stakeholder partnership to fulfill our mission of "connecting hinterland with ports, reducing logistics costs, and delivering net-zero, future-ready transportation across the nation."

